

Coping strategies for climate change anxiety: a perspective on building resilience through psychological capital

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ABSTRACT

As the global impacts of climate change become more apparent, there is a corresponding increase in the psychological effects of the phenomenon, including climate change anxiety, stress and helplessness or hopelessness. Positive psychology provides a promising approach for tackling these mental health challenges by consolidating mental strength and building resilience. In this article, we consider how positive psychological coping mechanisms can lessen the negative impacts of climate change on mental health, especially in vulnerable populations. Based on evidence-based concepts such as psychological capital, positive psychology interventions seek to empower individuals, bolstering their capacity for optimism, self-efficacy and problem solving. By transforming anxiety into proactive behaviour, interventions such as mindfulness, cognitive reframing and encouraging environmental engagement could assist individuals in navigating the emotional toll of climate change. Although these strategies are not a solution to the climate crisis itself, they are adaptive strategies that equip individuals and communities with the means to cope with climate-related challenges more effectively and take positive actions. This perspective note also addresses the significance of incorporating these techniques into public health educational initiatives and policy-making, highlighting the necessity of accessible interventions that can be tailored to various cultural and socioeconomic contexts. Accordingly, we specifically discuss how positive psychology can be leveraged to foster resilience and hope, providing insight into how these concepts can support mental health and well-being in an era of climate change crisis.

INTRODUCTION

The global climate crisis has far-reaching effects, extending beyond environmental and physical damages.¹ Whereas much of the attention has been placed on the ecological and economic repercussions of climate change, there has been relatively less focus on health, including the psychological effects of the crisis.¹ Chronic fear and worry about environmental deterioration and its consequences for the future is known as climate change anxiety, which emerged as a significant mental health and public health issue.² Climate change anxiety typically manifests as feelings of being overwhelmed, helplessness, grief and worry over the state of the world, often leading to severe mental health issues such as insomnia, headaches and panic attacks.³

Climate anxiety or climate change anxiety is especially prevalent among vulnerable populations such as persons with pre-existing mental conditions, marginalised groups, migrants and displaced persons, women, elderly people and young people.⁴ Their aim is to find sustainable and positive coping mechanisms to deal with the mounting psychological and emotional load associated with climate change.^{5 6} Climate change often invokes similar anxieties or emotional reactions such as ecological grief (grief experienced in response to actual or anticipated ecological loss) and solastalgia (distress brought on by environmental change in one's home environment) highlights the complexity of the effects of climate change on mental health.³

Positive psychology, therefore, provides a useful framework for developing coping mechanisms in response to climate change, emphasising fostering mental well-being and enhancing human strengths for health.⁵ In this perspective, we attempt to look at how positive psychology coping mechanisms, particularly Psychological Capital (PsyCap), could foster resilience-building that can assist individuals in managing anxiety associated with climate change. Furthermore, positive psychology could foster a solution-oriented mindset and collective efficacy, encouraging individuals and communities to take meaningful actions that contribute to societal and communal responses to the climate crisis.⁷ Positive psychology is a promising approach to bolster both individual and collective capacity to cope with climate-related stressors, with a particular focus on cultivating optimism, self-efficacy, resilience and hope using evidence-based interventions to promote public health.⁸ Beyond these, we hope to draw the attention of climate change researchers and generate interest in this area of climate change research.

CLIMATE CHANGE ADAPTIVE STRATEGIES

The WHO's operational framework for building climate resilient health systems⁹ provides a valuable perspective for evaluating the mental health effects of climate change and possible coping mechanisms. The framework emphasises the need for robust adaptive strategies in the face of climate change. Of particular interest is the eighth key component of the framework, which is concerned with climate-informed health initiatives.⁹ The mental health facet of this component highlights three objectives, including creating community-based monitoring



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systems for people with mental illness during extreme weather events, attending to the mental health needs of populations exposed to trauma and climate change disasters, and creating emergency preparedness plans specifically designed to meet the needs of mental health patients.⁹ However, it is crucial to understand that climate change anxiety is not inherently pathological but is a natural, even rational reaction to actual existential threats from the climate crisis. Recognising this could prevent the overmedicalisation of emotional reactions to the crisis, rather channelling these concerns into proactive and adaptive behaviours both at individual and community levels.⁴ Positive psychology offers valuable strategies for potentially achieving all three objectives, in order to improve climate-related mental health outcomes.⁵ Moreover, because the climate crisis is a public health crisis that needs evidence-informed adaptation strategies, understanding and leveraging positive psychology provides a window of hope.

POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY AND CLIMATE CHANGE

Positive psychology highlights the development of positive emotions, strengths and resilience, rather than the sole focus on the problems and challenges that exist within an individual's environment.⁷ In the practice of positive psychology, psychological interventions have been used to transform a mindset of hopelessness into a mindset of optimism in adverse situations.¹⁰ This concept can be applied in the context of climate change or climate crisis, as the approach has the potential to change the narrative surrounding climate change-induced helplessness to empowerment.¹⁰ It has been demonstrated that PsyCap, a key positive psychology construct that encompasses self-efficacy, optimism, resilience and hope, improves an individual's capacity to cope with adversity.⁷ Through the encouragement of a sense of control and purpose, PsyCap interventions like goal-setting activities and resilience training may help reduce anxiety related to climate change.⁶ Additionally, by encouraging active participation, PsyCap not only improves individual mental health but also contributes to collective efficacy and community-led climate initiatives.⁸ The aim is to reduce climate change anxiety and its consequences on individuals, the community and public health.

Climate action and self-efficacy

One of the best strategies to mitigate climate change anxiety is through the development of self-efficacy, which has been characterised as an individual's conviction or belief to bring about the needed change.¹¹ Environmentally friendly behaviour is most likely to be adopted by people who believe they can contribute solutions to the climate crisis, which can consequently reduce feelings of helplessness.² Interventions that focus on fostering self-efficacy, such as environmental education programmes that empower people to act, could be decisive in transforming the typical reaction to climate change from anxiety to constructive engagement.² As recommended by the WHO framework, self-efficacy-building activities could be incorporated into community-based monitoring systems by involving residents, particularly those with a history of mental health vulnerabilities, in decision-making and climate adaptation planning.⁹ These initiatives do not only foster a sense of agency, but promote community belongingness and mutual support, which are crucial for building and maintaining psychological resilience. However, it is important to recognise that placing too much emphasis on individual responsibility for coping and climate action may inadvertently take the focus off structural and systemic causes of the crisis. This risk is especially significant for those living

in resource-limited environments, where encouraging a sense of control without considering contextual limitations may worsen psychological discomfort and reinforce feelings of helplessness. Therefore, state actors like government through ministries and agencies, and non-governmental organisations and other institutions need to provide the needed climate change adaptation mechanisms to build both individual and community resilience.

Optimism and cognitive reframing

Another element of PsyCap is optimism, the ability of an individual to remain hopeful and upbeat in a negative situation, or in the face of adversity.⁸ Optimism in the context of climate change does not imply downplaying the gravity of the situation or the crisis, but rather refers to cognitive reframing, which is shifting the viewpoint from one of doom to hope.¹² The implementation of cognitive-behavioural therapy techniques, such as transforming thoughts and perceptions about climate change from those of a catastrophe to a manageable challenge, could help people to develop a more resilient and hopeful mindset so they can concentrate on finding solutions rather than being overwhelmed with fear.^{13 14} The belief is that in such helplessness, there is the likelihood that both individuals and communities would remain inactive and worsen their condition.

In line with the WHO framework's second objective, optimism training could be incorporated into programmes for psychological first aid and trauma response, in order to assist individuals and communities exposed to climate-related trauma.⁹ Such interventions help maintain motivation and reduce cognitive paralysis, enabling persons to engage in adaptive behaviour rather than be paralysed by dread. Nevertheless, fostering optimism needs to be done carefully, as the absence of a parallel systemic support may foster a false sense of control that has the potential to worsen their distress.

Resilience and adaptability

Resilience has often been described as the capacity to overcome hardship or bounce back from adversity and is considered essential for bolstering mental health in the face of the climate crisis.⁷ Programmes for resilience training, which are frequently employed in disaster preparedness and response, could be adapted to assist individuals and communities in coping with climate-related stress.¹⁵ This closely relates to the WHO's recommendation that emergency preparedness programmes need to incorporate mental health considerations and be climate-informed. Individuals can maintain and even improve their psychological well-being even in the face of environmental uncertainty by cultivating adaptive skills that bolster resilience.¹⁶ It has been recommended that bolstering resilience and adaptability is done through improving social connections, community engagement and collective problem-solving, which boost an individual and society's capacity to respond actively to climate issues.¹⁵ This collective involvement strengthens a sense of shared identity, purpose and belonging, which are important protective factors against anxiety and depression.

Hope as a coping mechanism

Hope is a key positive psychology and PsyCap construct that is essential for personal and collective mental well-being.¹⁴ Hope, in the context of climate change, refers to the belief that meaningful action can slow down the deteriorating effects of climate change.¹⁴ Hope can also mean that individuals and communities believe they have appropriate adaptive mechanisms to bounce back from climate change disasters. Studies have shown that individuals who have

higher levels of hope are more likely to engage in pro-environmental behaviours.¹⁷ Hope-promoting interventions, like community-driven sustainability initiatives, support the three WHO objectives by improving coping, strengthening community-based mental health networks and fostering a common belief in collective recovery and action.⁹ This can provide individuals with a sense of direction and lessen feelings of despair and dejection.¹⁴ Fostering hope in the face of the climate change crisis requires reinforcing the idea and belief that despite the gravity of the climate situation, positive outcomes may be achieved through appropriate individual and collective efforts.^{14 17} In contrast to resignation, which may provide momentary respite, hope is linked to psychological development, meaning-making and sustained motivation, which are critical for long-term mental health and community resilience against the crisis.¹⁷ However, it is critical to recognise that deeper engagement with climate change could intensify the feeling of anxiety. In such situations, interventions should be sensitive to psychological readiness, striking a balance between hopeful engagement, emotional support and realistic goal-setting in catastrophic climate change events.

MINDFULNESS-BASED POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY INTERVENTIONS TO MITIGATE CLIMATE CHANGE ANXIETY

The literature has shown mindfulness to be one of the most effective interventions for collectively improving self-efficacy, optimism, resilience and hope.^{18 19} Positive psychology interventions based on mindfulness have gained popularity as useful approaches for coping with emotional distress and anxiety.¹⁹ By improving these four constructs, mindfulness improves PsyCap by providing a targeted approach to cope with climate change anxiety.¹⁹ With regard to climate change, mindfulness practices like breathing exercises and meditation can help people regulate their emotions and reduce the debilitating feeling of powerlessness that frequently accompanies climate anxiety.²⁰ Mindfulness practices encourage a present-focused awareness and assist individuals in processing their feelings in a non-judgemental manner,¹⁸ serving as a useful coping strategy for climate change anxiety.

IMPLICATIONS FOR PUBLIC HEALTH

Addressing the effects of climate change on mental health may require incorporating coping mechanisms from positive psychology into public health initiatives.⁹ Public health campaigns should inculcate and promote PsyCap-based interventions, providing individuals and communities with the psychological resources needed to cope with climate anxiety. School curricula should include climate change educational initiatives that emphasise self-efficacy, hope, optimism and resilience to help young people deal with their climate-related anxieties. From a policy perspective, promoting mental health alongside taking positive climate action could result in an all-encompassing response to the climate crisis. Essentially, policies that promote and guarantee community-based resilience programmes, mental health assistance for climate change anxiety, and funding for climate change-related positive psychology interventions will ensure a healthier and more involved society.¹⁶ Moreover, public health research that studies climate change anxiety with cross-sectional and longitudinal designs is important to informed practice and policy.

CONCLUSIONS

Positive psychology offers a valid means of mitigating the psychological and emotional toll of climate change by bolstering self-efficacy, optimism, resilience and hope of individuals and communities at risk. By emphasising strengths rather than weaknesses, positive psychology coping techniques could transform climate change fear into constructive, proactive and solution-focused behaviours. As the

effects of climate change on mental health continue to worsen, incorporating positive psychology techniques into public health, education and policy is vital for building a resilient and empowered society.

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